BIHAR

NO LUV LOST WITH KUSHWAHA, PART-III


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STIR IT UP
Kushwaha at the press conference in Patna

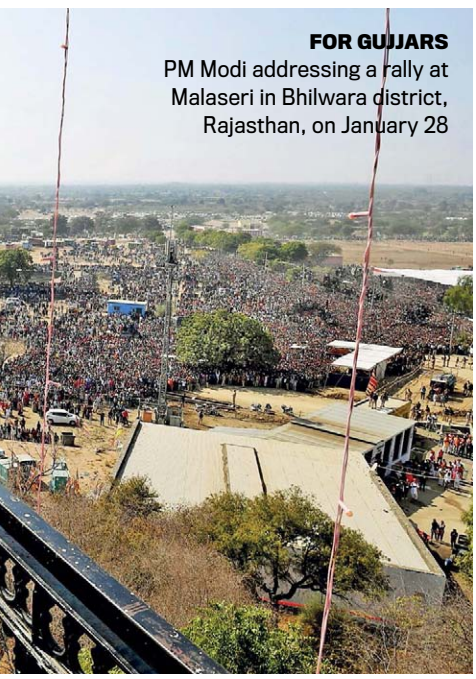
with the Rashtriya Janata Dal last year. With Nitish openly promoting Tejashwi, Kushwaha is obviously displeased, as he claims to represent sections that form the bedrock of Nitish's support base.

Kushwaha and his camp believe the Luv-Kush axis may not back Tejashwi as Nitish's successor. And if he strikes out on his own, he can at least retain his Koeri base. In a sense, this is a natural extension of the way Nitish himself fragmented the post-Mandal OBC vote, slicing away the Kurmi-Koeris. The ties between Nitish and Kushwaha are nearly three decades old, and the Bihar CM is known as his first political mentor. Kushwaha was elected as MLA for the first time in 2000; Nitish made him leader of the opposition in March 2004.

The duo have since had a blow hot, blow cold relationship. Kushwaha quit the JD(U) in 2005 after losing in both assembly polls that year. He returned in 2009, but again crossed swords with Nitish and quit both the JD(U) and his Rajya Sabha seat in 2013. A year later, he joined the BJP-led NDA and became a Union minister. In December 2018, he walked out to join the RJD-led grand alliance, only to dump it a year later after a disastrous electoral show. Despite the various political permutations he tried, Kushwaha drew a blank in the 2019 Lok Sabha and 2020 assembly polls.

On January 5, when he tweeted birthday wishes to the BJP's Sushil Kumar Modi, former deputy CM and now bitter critic of Nitish, it raised many eyebrows in the JD(U). A fortnight later, three Bihar BJP leaders called on Kushwaha at Delhi's AIIMS, where he was admitted for a routine check-up. Back in Patna, Kushwaha has by now held two press conferences holding forth against the CM. As things stand, NItish's grand alliance blueprint may need a quick routine check-up too. ■

time, and his late father Rajesh Pilot for 14 years before that. It would also be Modi's second visit to Rajasthan within a fortnight. His outreach is not limited to Pilot's Gujjar base, though—the attempt is to strike a balanced rapport with that caste group as well as the rival Meenas. Neither segment has much preferred to vote for the BJP.


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FOR GUJJARS
PM Modi addressing a rally at Malaseri in Bhilwara district, Rajasthan, on January 28

On January 28, Modi addressed a congregation to mark the incarnation festival of Shri Devnarayan, revered by Gujjars, at Malaseri in Bhilwara district. At Dausa, the PM's rally will mostly address Meenas. On November 1, 2022, Modi had addressed tribals at Mangarh Dham in Banswara district in the south, declared it a national monument and paid tributes to those massacred by the British there in 1913. Tribals of south Rajasthan support the BJP erratically. Along with the Gujjar-Meena stronghold in eastern Rajasthan—a Congress stronghold—they influence results in nearly 60 assembly seats.

Modi strategically avoided community-specific schemes, in an attempt to offer a counter-narrative to the Congress. Thus, contrary to speculation, he announced nothing for Mangarh Dham or Malaseri, using the occasion only to speak about the Centre's welfare work. A reference, however, was slipped in about how Gujjar deity Devnarayan appeared on a lotus, in which "we are born" (a reference to the BJP's symbol). Expect this messaging of symbolic kinship to be extended to the Meenas too.

Gujjars, an OBC community, have been angry with the BJP ever since incidents of police firing in 2007 and 2008 on their demonstrations seeking Scheduled Tribe status, something granted to Meenas decades back. The issue is at the root of the Meena-Gujjar conflict. Neither community voted for the BJP in the 2008 assembly polls. Even in 2013, when a Vasundhara Raje-led BJP won 163 seats in the 200-member house, reducing the Congress to 21, the latter performed better in the region. In 2018, Gujjars mostly voted Congress, hoping Pilot would be CM. Even Meenas did not fully support the BJP, which won only four seats out of the 28 seats where Gujjar-Meena votes matter.

The ST tag enables Meenas to corner jobs and offers protection under the SC/STs (Prevention of Atrocities) Act during disputes with Gujjars. Meenas have warned all governments against granting Gujjars ST status. Any party wooing either community runs the risk of a backlash from the other. That explains Modi's subtle, even-handed stance towards all blocs. But the heightened expectations that come with Modi visits, when unmet, may end up as a weapon in the hands of the Congress. ■